

Pega, we looked at different things and SCRUM really impressed me for a few reasons. One is that it is very intuitive. You don't have to wait for the project to complete to see the results of it. SCRUM divides everything into managed books and you can review your work at the end of each sprint. You can accordingly change direction and learn from it. The other thing about SCRUM is that it is a fairly lightweight process.

Q How important is open source technology for development at Pega?

Open source technology is a very important part of development processes in Pega. The plain logic of it is—if something is already available, why not use it rather than build that yourself. For instance, the Apache Foundation has a lot of things that we use in the development world or fit in different things. We believe in the open source vision of Big Data and we use Lucene as our search engine. In all, we have incorporated lots and lots of such components and adopted them in our day-to-day development. One of the things that is a part of our release process is that we scan all of our code, identify all the open source components, and make sure that we are complying with all the licences. I think it is a couple of hundred open source components that we use while developing at Pega.

Q What exactly are your reasons for using open source technology?

Open source technology gives us the benefit of other people's investments. In my mind, the whole principle of open source is that we have a lot of talented people who really have a passion for improving the products they are working on. There's a community that is probably much larger, which works on products that we could deploy. We focus on what we can do best, and leverage the 'best of breed' of other people who are focusing on what they do best.

Q Doesn't cost play a role when you consider open source technology?

Probably not, and let me tell you why this is the case for us. It is important to us that whatever technology we use is really solid and does what we need to do, because our customers are the biggest and most successful organisations across the globe. We have a very high-end target and user base. The top banks, insurance companies, manufacturing companies and health care service providers cannot compromise on their technology, which is primarily provided by us. So I can confidently say that we don't use open source technology to save money but we use it to improve our product. We, for sure, know that we have a good product and people buy it, and it commands a premium price. So we would never settle for anything less than the best available, and open source technology surely offers some of the best choices for us.

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People often ask me why we have such a big development facility in India and whether we came here to save money. The answer is 'No'; we are not here to save money. The reason we came to India is because I noticed that there are a lot of people from India who worked for us in the US. And they are really, really good people. I noticed that some of them were starting to say that they wanted to go back because India was reaching a stage where people could have a good lifestyle and career. They wanted to be a part of contributing to the home country's economy.

Then we thought that if they are planning to go back, there must be other people from the industry with similar plans. That got me interested in the idea that India has a lot of very talented people. I came here first in 2002 and met a lot of people, and made up my mind about setting up a facility here. When we began six years ago, we started with the idea that we will take only top engineers. We did not want to compromise because we did not come here to save money, but because we think there's some great talent here and we wanted to gain access to that.

Initially, we thought of hiring 40 great engineers to get the ball rolling. When we actually started the recruitment process, we realised that there is a lot of really awesome talent in the country and we started tapping into the talent pool. So we came here not for the low cost. We came here for high quality.

The same thing applies to our working with open source. It's not about cost savings, but about high quality.

Q So, do you find the right kind of open source skillsets in engineers in India?

A bunch of our engineers are very interested in the open source community and in keeping abreast with the best of technology, in general, and we encourage them to do that. A lot of them contribute to various open source projects. They mostly do that in their own time. If at all they need access to some of our resources and they need time to work on things, we kind of encourage them to do that. One of the things that we do at Pega is that we have hackathons almost once in each quarter at each of our locations. In the US, we do it the classic way that a hackathon is conducted—where people start working on one noon and only stop working the following noon. They stay up all night and organise themselves into teams to arrange for their food